

westernised Benazir. In the end, Musharraf simply had no choice but to accept their decision. However, it does seem that the Saudis did make clear to Sharif that he should not destabilise the system upon his return. Sharif's pronouncements since his return have been generally measured despite his opposition to Musharraf. He has also said that he believes in "national reconciliation".

Some American commentators, such as former ambassador to Pakistan Robert Oakley—known as "the Viceroy" during his stint in Pakistan after General Zia-ul-Haq's death—have remarked that Sharif may be a better bet for the US in the region. "Sharif may be Pakistan's future, an eventuality the US must prepare for," he wrote in *The Washington Post*. "He commands a strong following and, most importantly, has traditionally been strongly supported by the Pakistani army and intelligence services," he said. There is no other evidence, however, that Washington as a whole is pinning its hopes on Sharif, who is also viewed with suspicion because of his traditionally strong links to conservatives and

PPP joining in the boycott, Sharif's PML-N may be the only electorally strong party out of the running.

But analysts also point out that there are other factors that Sharif may be assessing. It is not entirely clear whether he can even legally contest the elections. If the Election Commission (EC) rules that he is a convicted felon—there is confusion whether charges against him for hijacking and terrorism were "withdrawn" or whether he was simply "pardoned after conviction"—

PML-N. For its part, PML—which was formed from the breakaway hump of Sharif's party—is in a wait-and-watch mode. It certainly faces a stiff challenge with his return and risks losing members through defections. Some defections have already taken place—former state minister Hina Rabbani Khar has joined PPP—while it has also decided to jettison close Musharraf aides. Its leaders, the Chaudhries of Gujarat, do not possess the nerves or popularity for a bruising contest. Among the most

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Sworn in as a civilian President, Musharraf will continue to have the powers to dismiss the government and preside over the National Security Council

the religious right. "I don't know him well enough," is how President Bush responded when asked about Sharif's political inclinations.

Riding high on a wave of public adulation for his apparently "principled stand" in favour of restoration of the judiciary and against the curbs on the electronic media, Sharif has repeatedly said he would like to boycott the polls to deny Musharraf legitimacy. But his decision is far from made and he has been careful to leave the option of contesting open, having himself filed his candidacy papers. For one, he may be reluctant to boycott the polls if he is unable to convince Benazir to do the same. In fact, in recent interviews he has pleaded with Benazir to take a united stand with him. Without

he may be ineligible to run for a parliamentary seat. Such a ruling would, however, in effect force Sharif to boycott polls even if he does not want to. Sharif may also be assessing his party's chances in the upcoming elections. "Given the disorganised and hurried manner in which the party's candidacies were filed on the EC deadline a day after Nawaz returned," says Zaffar Abbas, resident editor of *Dawn*, "it is not clear if the PML-N has enough winnable candidates. He himself may not even know some of his own candidates." How Sharif assesses his party's chances may influence the route he takes.

One of Sharif's options, if he does not boycott the polls, is to go for a seat-adjustment with PPP in the hopes of wiping out the former King's Party—

prominent casualties are: former prime minister Shaukat Aziz and former ministers Ejazul Haq, Zobeida Jalal and Wasi Zafar.

A seat adjustment with Sharif's PML-N—which is likely to sweep Punjab's urban areas—or a three-way contest with both PML-N and PML in the race, would suit PPP just fine. In the latter case, the anti-PPP vote in Punjab—which holds almost 50 per cent of the national seats, is most likely to get split, allowing Benazir's party to emerge victorious. It is reasonably sure of carrying Sindh despite losing the urban areas to MQM. Its only worry may be the political ramifications of a PML-N boycott, which, in addition to taking the high moral ground from the PPP, would pit it in a two-way race against an establishment-supported PML. For their part, however, party insiders are convinced that Sharif will not boycott the polls.

So what does all this mean for

With a hung election likely, Musharraf will continue to be the kingmaker.